

Understanding behaviour

Behaviour is one of the ways in which we communicate: it tells other people how we are feeling and what we want. Sometimes, our behaviour might be more challenging than at other times.

As well as being a way to communicate for people with autism, behaviour can be:

- a coping mechanism – perhaps a way of dealing with situations that are unpredictable or stressful
- a way to manage sensory issues
- a learned behaviour that achieves a certain outcome, for example shouting in the supermarket means they get to leave an environment that they don't like
- a pleasurable activity, for example some people with autism find that repetitive movements such as rocking or hand-flapping are calming and enjoyable.

An autistic child may use behaviour in one, or all, of these ways. By understanding the cause of this child's behaviour and the purpose it serves, it is possible to find ways to respond. Importantly, you can help your child to self-manage their behaviour (although it is worth noting at this point that if the behaviour serves a useful purpose and does not have an adverse effect on anyone, it may not need to be managed or changed).

Challenging Behaviour

The term 'challenging behaviour' is generally used to describe severely problematic or socially unacceptable behaviour that, nonetheless, we can respond to in practical ways.

Behaviour is defined as 'challenging' in terms of the costs to the individual and the world around them.

It reinforces the fact that not all 'different' behaviour is necessarily challenging behaviour that requires intervention; it depends upon the severity of the behaviour and its impact on a person's quality of life – as well as the lives of those around them

Types of challenging behaviour

Challenging behaviour can take a number of forms and include:

- physically aggressive behaviour
- self-injurious behaviour
- verbal abuse, including shouting and swearing
- sounds that other people find distressing.

Challenging physical behaviour may be targeted towards others and include slapping, biting, scratching, hair pulling, kicking and spitting. A person might also break or damage property or equipment. This behaviour is not necessarily aimed at anyone in particular: rather, the person may have lost control and be hitting out in anxiety or frustration.

Self-injurious behaviour can include hand biting, head-butting, scratching, picking, gouging and not eating.

This behaviour might be a way for a person to refocus their attention, and therefore reduce anxiety, in a specific situation. It could be done to induce endorphins which help the person to feel better, or it may be about gaining sensory stimulation.

Challenging behaviour can also be verbal, whether verbal abuse such as swearing or shouting, or other sounds that people find distressing or difficult to cope with.

While all of these behaviours can be difficult to cope with, they will serve a purpose for the person with autism. If the behaviour is something that is undesired but doesn't place anyone in immediate danger (for example, spitting), it may be better to gradually replace it with a more acceptable behaviour.

Coping with challenging behaviour

Challenging behaviour is difficult for your child and for those around them. **It is really important to recognise the effect that challenging behaviour has on you, as a support worker, and to try and manage your reaction to it.**

The way in which we react to someone's behaviour affects the way they respond to us. For example, if we can deal with challenging behaviour in a calm, consistent manner we are more likely to be able to manage the situation effectively and hopefully stop the behaviour from escalating. If we become angry or upset and adopt a challenging posture and demeanour, then our child may become more confused, anxious or angry.

If your child has gone into 'meltdown' they have lost control and really need support to manage their behaviour.

Identifying the causes of challenging behaviour

For people with autism, behaviour is often influenced by anxiety, sensory differences, or difficulties with communication and interaction. We will look at all these areas in more detail in this section.

Anxiety

Although anxiety isn't a characteristic of autism itself, many people with autism are anxious a lot of the time because they have to navigate a world which they can find unpredictable and frightening. One common cause of anxiety is a lack of predictability, which is linked to difficulties with social imagination. Your child may have trouble predicting what will happen next in social situations; they may also have problems understanding the consequences of their own or others' actions.

Similarly, some of the ritualistic behaviours that people with autism exhibit may be a way of imposing order on what, to them, is a chaotic world. Repetitive movements such as rocking or spinning may help your child to feel calm and maintain their equilibrium. Repetitive behaviour may also serve to express happiness, excitement and joy. This release of energy isn't so unusual: just look at football fans when their team scores!

Social interaction difficulties are also a feature of autism. Your child may become anxious in social situations if they are unsure how to interact with others, how they are 'supposed' to behave or what they are 'supposed' to say. It is possible that they might initiate interaction by, for example, slapping or hitting as they know that this produces a reaction but are unaware of its negative impact upon others.

Here are some other ways in which anxiety can affect a person's behaviour.

Discomfort: Sometimes, challenging behaviour can be caused by a trigger in the environment, such as sensory stimuli, (bright lights or a particular noise) which can cause discomfort, but can also be related to a phobia (for example, dogs). In some cases, your child may anticipate the trigger (they are going to the park so expect to see a dog) and it is this anticipation which will cause the discomfort.

Change: A child with autism can find any kind of change difficult. Change can lead to an increase in anxiety and this can quickly become overwhelming for your child.

Escape or avoidance: Your child's behaviour may be an indication that they want to escape or avoid a situation – they may find social interaction difficult and prefer to avoid it, or they may wish to leave a conversation or have a bit of time to themselves, but not be able to communicate this.

Denial of wishes: If your child is doing something they enjoy and is asked to stop, they may feel anxious because the activity is about to stop, or frustrated because they don't understand why it has to stop.

Transition: People with autism can find unstructured time particularly stressful. Some examples of transition times include waiting for an activity to start, or leaving somewhere and going home. There is an element of uncertainty at these times and your child may not be sure what they should do; this is likely to cause anxiety.

Mood or physical state: If your child is tired, hungry, stressed or ill they may become more anxious or frustrated than usual, or more sensitive to sensory stimuli, for example, light or noise.

Sensory differences: As explained in the sensory section, sensory differences can cause extreme anxiety and pain.

Social and communication difficulties: As mentioned above these difficulties can lead to anxiety and possibly challenging behaviour.

Overload or 'meltdown'

There are times when things can get too much and your child may lose control. This is commonly called a 'meltdown', though you may also hear it referred to as an explosion, an outburst or a crisis incident.

A meltdown is when a person has completely lost control and is at their most challenging. Beforehand, there will usually be a period of escalation when a person becomes increasingly frustrated or anxious: meltdowns can build up over minutes, hours, days or even weeks. At this time, it is likely a trigger, or a series of triggers will cause the person to move from their normal emotional state ('baseline') to a heightened state of anxiety. It is therefore very important to always know the possible triggers of the person you are supporting (these will be included in the profile if known).

People with autism may have a higher baseline than others. "Although my child's temper seems to go from 0 to 60 miles per hour in three seconds, actually he wakes up at 45 miles per hour, so it takes less to cause a meltdown." Parent

During the escalation stage, you may notice changes in behaviour. For example, your child might begin making more noise than usual, they might be covering their ears, or they might begin pacing or swearing.

Losing control is scary, challenging and upsetting for a person with autism. Afterwards, your child may feel distressed or regretful about what has happened and perhaps seek comfort and reassurance. It can be difficult for you to offer comfort if you have just been through the experience of a meltdown: you may have been injured or have pent-up feelings of your own. Nonetheless, do try to offer support and reassurance.

Try also to take a bit of time to deal with any residual feelings you have and if possible talk to someone else and 'debrief'. This will help everyone involved to continue supporting your child in a consistent, constructive way.

Assessing and monitoring behaviour

It's useful to think about the ways in which you can assess your child's behaviour, with a view to understanding the function that a particular behaviour might serve. Once you understand where the behaviour comes from and what it means, you can help your child to find more effective and appropriate ways of communicating.

To understand any behaviour, we need first to think about its function. We also need to think about the characteristics of autism and how these may affect or contribute to your child's behaviour. You can use the acronym SEAT to help you remember some of the functions that a behaviour might serve:

Sensory: Is it a sensory issue?

Escape: Are they unhappy with something that's happening?

Attention: Have they got the attention they need?

Tangible: Are they trying to get some "thing" e.g. food or a toy?

It can be helpful to use a behaviour diary to try and determine the reason for a particular behaviour. A behaviour diary allows you to monitor your child's behaviour over time, to notice patterns and to identify possible causes. For example, your child may always behave in a particular way at the end of the session. You can always discuss any behaviour issues with the office team.